lay claim to being expert media analysts, to ask some hard questions on the role that the media have played in this case, and with regard to the representation of ‘terrorism and counter-terrorism’ in general, and provoke some reason for introspection within the community of media practitioners.

A thorough enquiry into these matters will make it necessary for us to examine a whole range of materials— charge sheets, court records, depositions, defence and prosecution arguments, judgements as well as news reports, television news and current affairs programmes, televised enactments or dramatizations and feature length fiction films.[1]

This text is culled from preliminary notes towards such an exercise, but even in making these notes I have become aware of the fact that the task of reflection on the media requires us to consider media materials, not as isolates, but as elements in a networked reality, where cinema, television, newspaper reportage and even public service messages enter into elaborate interweaving feedback loops that reinforce and sustain each other, either through direct quotation, or through narrative ‘enhancements’ that create a situation where each message enhances its claim to credibility by relying on the credentials of the other. Thus, when hearing a voice say authoritatively on a televised commentary accompanying a visual of a slain man’s visage that the face belongs to a ‘terrorist’, we are implicitly being asked to invoke ‘images’ of terrorists’ faces that we may have seen in fiction films. Conversely, when a fictional film consciously evokes the aesthetic register of the rough-hewn ‘documentary’ look and feel of news reportage when invoking terrorism, it is doing so in order to buttress its own claim to credibility. Events and processes such as the ‘reading’ of 13 December and its aftermath take place at the intersections of a densely networked media space, where messages, memories, events and mediums relay and overlay each other. These realities make the task of sophisticated and sensitive readings of media not an academic excercise but an urgent political task, that has bearings not only on the destinies of our polity but also, as in the 13 December case, on the life and death of individuals. The galling neglect, incapacity or unwilllingess, on the part of a vast majority of media scholars and critics in India to undertake this excercise, and the lax ethical standards of many media practitioners has in the final analysis to be read against what happens to us as a polity, and what happens to the lives of individuals and to those close to them.